



P2P VPN

The Pirate Bay launches a VPN service aimed at P2P users

Security suites

with a lot of features. One of the features is the ability to set the firewall into gaming mode which allows access of games to the internet through the firewall without any hassles. For those who don't have an internet connection, AVG allows updating of downloaded virus definition by importing them from a folder.

eScan Internet Security's approach towards flash drives can be considered a little over-the-top, but is an effective way to make sure no one infects your PC with a flash drive. It requires the user to enter a password to access the flash drive. This is great if you have many users using a single PC. An easy-to-use parental control system is available as well.

Kaspersky has one of the nicest looking interfaces and one they've implemented is an on-screen keyboard that allows users to type in passwords on online banking and shopping sites without

worrying about the password logged. Onscreen keyboard is available with Windows, but the suite makes it easily accessible. It even scans your system for vulnerabilities asking you to patch the bugs. All the alerts are displayed in one single window. The updating was a bit of a problem for us. We updated and it kept on asking for even more updates. After a couple of updates and a reboot or two, everything was back to normal.

ESET Smart Security has basic features, but the customisations and controls available for those functions are very detailed. This might be a good thing, but for users looking for a simple solution, this might be a little overwhelming. Panda Internet Security 2009 monitors the wireless network and if a new PC appears, it shows up an alert asking whether it is to be allowed access to the PC or not. As part of the services

HOW WE TESTED

All the tests were run on Windows XP with the internal firewall turned off. We made a disc image of this installation of Windows. After every security suite was tested, we restored the system back to its initial clean state with no viruses present or any security suite installed. The next security suite would then be installed and all updates completed. We used the default settings with which the suites were installed. Tweaking the settings would make it unfair.

The first component to be tested was the antivirus. We had a collection of around 300 viruses from the last couple of years all put into a folder on the drive. We copied the files from a flash drive and checked if the scanner would detect the viruses on the flash drive itself. This folder was copied to the local drive and then scanned to see how many of the viruses

and worms were detected by the suites. As part of a basic network test, we did some ping flood attacks and then some port scanning trying to find if the security suites detected these attacks and displayed any security alerts or messages.

For the spam, we setup two different dummy accounts with POP3 access enabled. One after the other, we setup Outlook Express to download mails from these accounts. One of the accounts had mails that could exploit the vulnerabilities of mail clients and the other had spam mails in it. We downloaded mails using Outlook Express trying to see if any of the suites detected and filtered the mail.

Those using Firefox or Opera are rarely victims of spyware and malicious scripts on the internet, so we used Internet Explorer to access some sites with popups and ADs. At the same time, we also looked at

the parental control features of suites which had them that could block the explicit content on these sites.

One of the biggest complaints that users have about security suites is that they are very high on system resources and the PC slows down a lot once an antivirus or security suite is installed. We checked the memory consumption of the suites and the accompanying services when idle and then again while scanning the drive for viruses.

Finally, we must emphasise that we've only used a small sample of viruses available and so the detection results from this test are not an accurate way to judge the performance of a suite. The fact is that there are new viruses released every day and the performance of every suite will differ every day. A lot depends on the frequency of the update.



menu, Panda Internet Security lets you create rescue disks and upload suspicious files to their database for inspection.

Detection rates

In all, we had 289 viruses and trojans packed into separate ZIP files and the antivirus component of the suites had to scan each ZIP file before detecting the virus and then trying to either clean it or quarantine it. All the suites detected almost all the viruses in the folder, with a few minor exceptions. It was odd to find

suites that detected more viruses and worms than we put into the folder. AVG Internet Security and Kaspersky Internet Security detected more viruses than were in the test sample. All the suites were able to delete the viruses from the folder, but Kaspersky Internet Security suite was one the top performing ones that could fix the files.

K7TotalSecurity 9.0 was able to detect all the viruses accurately.

Most users today use web-based mail services and many of these have built-in spam removal features. Developers advertise their suites' ability to locally clear spam from mail clients. We used Outlook Express because it was the client that came bundled with every Windows installation. We were shocked to see almost none of the suites being able to filter out spam or even the set of vulnerability test mails. Once

again, McAfee stood out and it was able to find and mark vulnerability and spam mails. It did so once the mail had been downloaded to the mail client. ESET's Smart Security 4 was the other one which was capable of finding the spam mail. It almost detected all the spam accurately, but it couldn't detect any of the vulnerability test mails.

Some of the other suites such as K7TotalSecurity required the user to train the filter for the spam and over time, it could be more effective. On a clean install, the suite couldn't catch any of the vulnerability test mails or the spam. F-Secure InternetSecurity 2009 was able to detect some of the sites with popups and banners.

There were no such issues as far as network security was concerned. All the firewalls blocked the denial of service (DoS) attempts and the port scans completely. Kaspersky Internet Security displayed clear alerts pointing out to the source of the attack and it even blocked the entire IP. eScan Internet Security and solution from Kaspersky were able to block out objectionable content